

A Multicultural Feminist Model of Mentoring

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This article identifies ways professionals perpetuate misperceptions about mentoring when engaging in traditional methods of mentoring. Fassinger's feminist model of mentoring is expanded by incorporating multicultural elements into the model. The authors' definition of 'multiculturalism' is inclusive of individuals from different races, ethnicities, socioeconomic strata, ability levels, sexual orientations, religious affiliations, etc. Misperceptions and realities associated with the revised multicultural feminist mentoring model are discussed regarding their applicability to students in academe.

The process of mentoring has been of keen interest among a variety of professions, including business and industry (e.g., Baugh, Lankau, & Scandura, 1996; Blake-Beard, 1999; Burke & McKeen, 1997; Dreher & Cox, 1996; Ensher & Murphy, 1997), teacher training (e.g., Maynard & Furlong, 1993), higher education (e.g., Bowman, Kite, Branscombe, & Williams, 1999; Ramey, 1995), law (e.g., Riley & Wrench, 1985) as well as psychology and counseling (e.g., Bruce, 1995; Tentoni, 1995). According to Colley (2000), the number of publications about mentoring has skyrocketed; an average of 12 articles was published on the topic between 1979-84, compared to an average of 150 articles published at the close of the last decade.

Many mentors and mentees enter into relationships with simplistic, even glorified conceptualizations of mentoring. Both the mentor and the mentee expect to engage in a mutually rewarding relationship free of conflict or difficulty. This approach, however, does not prepare either party adequately for the potential challenges that are likely to await them as a result of this joint venture. Misperceptions about mentoring will continue to be perpetuated unless

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professionals who are invested in promoting the development of their students and junior colleagues acknowledge that the existing rose-colored depictions of mentoring are misleading. Although there are certainly advantages associated with mentoring, there are numerous issues that need to be addressed. First, there are disagreements regarding the definition of mentoring and what that relationship entails. Second, the literature on mentoring has not resulted in consistent findings about the benefits associated with mentoring relationships. Finally, historically, professionals have tended to implement a Procrustean (i.e., one size fits all) model of mentoring, assuming that traditional models of mentoring can be used to facilitate the growth of all people. The vast majority of existing conceptualizations of mentoring fail to acknowledge the likelihood that difference in life histories and life contexts of both the mentor and the mentee may impact the mentoring relationship. The purpose of this article is to shed light on these problematic issues and to present a revised model of mentoring that begins to address these shortcomings.

definitional difficulties associated with mentoring

One common criticism discussed in the mentoring literature is the absence of a clear, universal definition of mentoring (e.g., Carruthers, 1993; Crosby, 1999; Riley & Wrench, 1985; Tentoni, 1995). Lack of a consistent definition perpetuates the perception that mentoring relationships are simplistic when, in fact, they are quite complex. The terms sponsorship (i.e., the process of advancing the career of others through the informal strategies that exist in the professional environment [Clark & Corcoran, 1986]), instrumental support (i.e., a similar process that does not contain psychosocial support [Thomas, 1993]), and role modeling (e.g., the intentional or unintentional modeling of skills that may be relevant to the personal and/or professional development of others [Crosby, 1999]) often are used interchangeably with mentoring. While sponsorship, instrumental support, and role modeling certainly represent aspects of mentoring, they are not synonymous with it (Clark & Corcoran, 1986).

The ongoing definitional problem associated with mentoring poses serious difficulties. Not only does it call into question the validity of research findings, but it also limits our ability to clearly conceptualize the process of mentoring and the dimensions that underlie this process. A study conducted by Riley and Wrench (1985) illustrated how differences in perceptions of the definition of mentoring can impact research results. Female lawyers whose mentoring relationship met a more stringent definition were found to report higher levels of career satisfaction and success than those women lawyers whose mentoring relationships met less stringent criteria. At the very least, researchers must clearly operationalize their definition of the term mentoring so that meaningful comparisons between studies can be made.

In conclusion, we believe that the term mentoring should only be applied to those professional relationships that include both instrumental and psychosocial elements. Further, both mentor and mentee must have a personal and professional investment in the relationship (Crosby, 1999). Failure to clearly define (and understand) the mentoring process is problematic in that it will result in misleading research findings (e.g., the ability to understand the extent to which mentoring is associated with professional development, satisfaction, and "success"). Further, the erroneous information associated with mentoring will continue to be perpetuated and the efficacy of mentoring will not be established.

research-related misperceptions and challenges

We believe that both mentors and mentees tend to cling to an idealized image of mentoring where such relationships are viewed as both productive and conflict-free. Certainly, a preponderance of the research literature identifies a number of benefits associated with mentoring. These benefits include greater involvement in professional activities among female graduate students (e.g., Lark & Croteau, 1998), greater job success and satisfaction among women (e.g., Baugh et al., 1996; Burke & McKeen, 1997; Riley & Wrench, 1985), attaining higher level professional positions (e.g., Ramey, 1995), and higher annual incomes if mentored by White males (e.g., Dreher & Cox, 1996). Few scholars focus on benefits for the mentor (one notable exception is Atkinson, Neville and Casas [1991]).

Although the majority of the research literature presents mentoring in a positive light, a substantial portion of the literature base suggests that mentoring is not always a positive experience (e.g., Murrell, Crosby, & Ely, 1999). First, the transitions that occur during all aspects of the mentoring relationship may result in negative feelings. These feelings may occur when the mentor and mentee begin to redefine their roles, acknowledge that certain professional needs cannot be met, and when shifts in power and perceived expertise emerge (Kram, 1983). Second, mentoring relationships may be more problematic when they are forced rather than if they develop as a result of mutual choice (Carruthers, 1993). Further, non-mentored peers may become jealous of their colleagues, particularly when they are not perceived as being as gifted as their mentored peers (Carruthers, 1993). Finally, jealousy toward the mentee on the part of the mentor may result in failure to promote mentees to their fullest capabilities (Carruthers, 1993; Clark & Corcoran, 1986).

Other problematic aspects of mentoring are more relevant to individuals who are not from privileged groups or who are from groups who do not have a significant representation in a given career or profession. Although some of these

individuals have benefited from mentoring relationships with White males, the literature suggests they have a desire to be mentored by individuals who are similar to them (Murrell et al., 1999). Unfortunately, it is difficult for these individuals to find mentors with whom they can identify based on gender, sexual orientation, race/ethnicity, and similarities in social class (Bowman et al., 1999; Carruthers, 1993; Chandler, 1996; Clark & Corcoran, 1986; Lark & Croteau, 1998) or who can serve as professional and/or personal lifestyle role models (Bruce, 1995; Schweibert, Deck, Bradshaw, Scott, & Harper, 1999). In addition, mentors from groups with low societal status (e.g., women and ethnic/racial minorities) may be less effective in their ability to mentor compared to their White male counterparts, given their limitations in status and power (Dreher & Cox, 1996). These individuals, especially if they are in the earlier stages of their own professional development, may not yet have established connections with more powerful and respected individuals within their profession that are needed to mentor others. Furthermore, they may not have adequate time and resources to promote others who are also considered to be "junior" in that work environment.

Cross-gender relationships also are frequently discussed in the literature due to the perceived and real difficulties associated with them. These relationships are more likely to result in romantic and sexual innuendo and overtones (Burke & McKeen, 1997; Carruthers, 1993). For the female mentee with a male mentor, there is a risk that she will be viewed as a token by her constituents (Chandler, 1996), and she is less likely to be included in more informal networking activities (Ragins & McFarlin, 1990). These women are sometimes viewed by their mentors as not taking their professional goals seriously, and, therefore, they may be mentored in a qualitatively different way from men (Chandler, 1996; Clark & Corcoran, 1986; Schweibert et al., 1999). Often they are not afforded some of the professional development opportunities that may be offered to their male counterparts (Clark & Corcoran, 1986). Related to this, women's career trajectories may be different from men's career tracks (Chandler, 1996; Schweibert et al., 1999).

In conclusion, professionals need to refrain from perpetuating the perception that mentoring relationships are conflict-free encounters. Existing research clearly identifies not only the benefits but also the challenges associated with existing models of mentoring.

existing models of mentoring

TRADITIONAL MODELS OF MENTORING

Although numerous models of mentoring have been proposed (e.g., Colley, 2000; Maynard & Furlong, 1993; Tentoni, 1995), perhaps the most well-known and applied model of mentoring was introduced by Kram over 20 years ago (Kram, 1983). Kram's model represented a significant advancement in the conceptualization of mentoring in that it focused both on content and process. Her model described the types of activities involved in the mentoring process (i.e., career and psychosocial functions).

Further, it had a developmental focus and described the stages underlying the mentoring process over time. Finally, Kram identified both the benefits and conflicts that emerge during the relationship.

RELATIONAL MODELS OF MENTORING

Concerns have been voiced about the applicability of traditional mentoring models to diverse groups of individuals. Colley (2000) expressed her concern that traditional models of mentoring have been directive and hierarchical in nature. They are based on paternalistic ideologies and male models of development and perpetuate the view that one style of mentoring will meet the majority of mentees' professional development needs. These concerns center on how women, people of color, and other marginalized people may have different needs than the historically predominant White male mentee.

For women, these concerns may include a desire to be mentored by women who exhibit an ability to integrate both career and family aspects of their lives (Bruce, 1995; Clark & Corcoran, 1986; Schweibert et al., 1999). Women may feel pressured to maintain a strong allegiance to their families while they strive to excel professionally (Chandler, 1996). Women may have interest in being mentored as intensely as their male counterparts despite the fact that they may enter the profession at an older age and/or intermittently interrupt their career paths due to family/childcare responsibilities (Schweibert et al.). Furthermore, women may express a wish to be mentored by same-gender mentors, particularly when they are employed in non-traditional settings (Schweibert et al.), and may prefer that the mentoring process have an interpersonal focus (Chandler, 1996; Kalbfleisch & Keyton, 1995; Schweibert et al.).

Similar themes emerge regarding the mentoring needs of people of color and other marginalized individuals (Bowman et al., 1999; Chandler, 1996; Lark & Croteau, 1998; Ramey, 1995). The mentoring needs of women of color may be further complicated by the fact that they are more likely to experience discrimination as a result of both their ethnic/racial background and their gender (Blake, 1999; Ramey, 1995; Schweibert et al., 1999). The lack of role models and support for members of these marginalized groups may make it even more challenging to deal with such systematic discrimination. Further, individuals from these groups often have other concerns that can complicate identifying and establishing a mentoring relationship. Lark and Croteau's qualitative study indicated that gay, lesbian, and bisexual (GLB) counseling psychology graduate students' levels of safety and outness influenced the degree to which they sought mentors who were also GLB— or at the very least, GLB-affirmative. Thomas (1993) found that the most productive cross-race mentoring relationships were those in which both parties shared the same strategy for addressing racial differences.

A more relational model of mentoring is one possible solution to many of the limitations associated with the more traditional models of mentoring. Kalbfleish and Keyton (1995) present a compelling case for making this shift. They advocate a mentoring model that is sensitive to the variety of career paths that individuals take, that acknowledges the impact of the work environment on individuals who are viewed as minorities in their specific professional context, and that details the benefits associated with the interpersonal aspect of the mentoring relationship. This type of mentoring relationship is more likely to result in mutually enhanced relationships in which both individuals can be authentically involved with one another.

Kalbfleish and Keyton's (1995) model focuses specifically on women; other elements of diversity are discussed peripherally. Further, they recommend that only women should mentor women. Although they suggest that many of the pitfalls associated with cross-gender mentoring can be alleviated by having women mentor women, this recommendation is of limited utility given the lack of mentors for both women and marginalized people. Fassinger's (1997) feminist model of mentoring is one that can be employed by both female and male mentors to their work with diverse mentees.

FASSINGER'S FEMINIST MENTORING MODEL

Fassinger (1997) proposed what we consider to be one of the most progressive and broadly applicable models of mentoring to date. Her feminist model places substantial emphasis on the relational component of mentoring as well as issues related to power and empowerment. The attention she gives to the benefits experienced by both the mentor and the mentee is noteworthy, as few scholars focus on this aspect of mentoring relationships (e.g., Atkinson, Casas, & Neville, 1994). In Fassinger's model, the mentor recognizes the existence of power differences between him/herself and the mentee, openly acknowledges these differences, and strives to use power as a means for empowering the mentee. Thus, the ultimate outcome of the relationship does not result in perpetuating socially defined power dynamics. Fassinger's model is unique in that it explicitly identifies diversity as a salient aspect of the mentoring relationship that deserves attention within the mentoring relationship.

Although Fassinger's feminist model of mentoring represents a concerted effort to better understand and place greater value on the relational aspect of the mentoring process, it is problematic in one significant way. Attention to multicultural issues and respect for cultural differences is discussed as an important dimension of the model, but not infused explicitly throughout the model. We recommend a revision of Fassinger's model that integrates multiculturalism with feminist theory.

a reconceptualization of mentoring from a multicultural feminist perspective

Based on our conceptualizations of multiculturalism and feminism, we conceptualize multicultural feminist mentoring (MFM) as an interactive process in which differences are (a) clearly identified, (b) explored when appropriate (e.g., Thomas, 1993) in order to determine their relevance to the relationship and each individual's professional development, and (c) ultimately result in a relational exchange that is respectful of differences. Finally, in keeping with Blake's (1999) suggestions, it is important for mentors to work to become more knowledgeable about the tensions that exist between feminism and multicultural issues and to find ways to address and work through these tensions in order to foster more satisfying and useful mentoring relationships.

a multicultural feminist mentoring model

We revised Fassinger's (1997) model to reflect a multicultural approach to mentoring. We did this both by explicating what was implicit and by infusing pertinent multicultural issues as indicated by scholarly work in the mentoring literature. Our presentation of Fassinger's revised model follows and includes a discussion of each of the five dimensions contained in her model. We also explicate the benefits of a MFM model, including those that benefit the larger culture in which this kind of mentoring occurs (Fassinger noted in her paper that MFM relationships are "dangerous" as they "constitute a collective challenge to the status quo" [p. 16]). A summary of our revision of Fassinger's model can be found in Table 1.

This dimension is described by Fassinger (1997) as the creation of a relationship "built on the sharing of power, mutuality, equality, and respect" (p. 8). In her model, power dynamics are not denied but rather fully examined. Evaluative components of the relationship are discussed. Further, the mentor does not confer the power s/he holds (due to race, position, gender, etc.) but rather focuses on empowering the mentee. The goal is to teach mentees that they are their own source of "truth, knowledge, judgment and ... authority" (p. 4). The mentor's focus is not on the mentor's own needs, but on the needs of the mentee. This dimension of Fassinger's model is consistent with Heinrich's (1995) thoughts about the issue of power in mentoring relationships. According to Heinrich (1995), power differences are acknowledged within the relationship, the mentor facilitates the professional development of the mentee, and this developmental process occurs through "mutual empathy, mutual empowerment, mutual caretaking with a healthy degree of reciprocity, and authenticity marked by role flexibility" (p. 463).

TABLE 1
Multicultural-Feminist Mentoring Model

Characteristics	Benefits to Mentor	Benefits to Mentee
Rethinking of Power Eschews hierarchies, emphasis on sharing power	Gains colleague	Feels competent
Recognition of power differences BUT goal is NOT to wield one's power but to use it to empower others		Learns to trust, respect self
Puts own needs secondary to mentee		
<i>Examination of privilege within the relationship and the environment</i>		
<i>Respect for existing differences between the mentor and the mentee</i>		
Emphasis on Relational Mentoring is genuine	Gains support, friendship	Gains support
Mentoring is both task- and relationship-oriented	Greater understanding of multicultural issues	Gains appreciation of balance
Mentor shows both strengths and flaws		Develops networks
Feedback occurs within the relationship		
<i>Mentor takes the responsibility for raising multicultural issues with all mentees</i>		
<i>Mentees are encouraged to seek out other mentors/sponsors when appropriate</i>		
Valuing Collaboration Mentor and mentee work side-by-side on projects	Valuable task assistance	Gains direct experience
All voices are valued	Increases productivity	Observes close model
<i>Participation is not prescribed by majority culture</i>	Higher quality products	Contributions respected
<i>Diverse perspectives are encouraged</i>		

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TABLE 1 (Continued)
Multicultural-Feminist Mentoring Model

Characteristics	Benefits to Mentor	Benefits to Mentee
Integration of Dichotomies		
Focus on developing a congruent sense of self	Reinforces self-congruence	Respects knowledge
Both sides of the continuum are valued		<i>Respects feelings</i>
Experiences gained in a non-majority culture are perceived as valuable		Develops self-congruence
Incorporation of Political Analysis		
Acknowledgment that education/science/work/life are not value-free	Re-empowers self	Gains awareness
Mainstream values (e.g., sexism, racism, and homophobia) within both individuals and institutions are challenged	Influences status quo	Is empowered to work toward social change
Social advocacy and social justice activities are supported		
Commitment to Diversity		
The material previously contained in this dimension has been incorporated into the five preceding dimensions.		

Note. Adapted from Fassinger (1997). Additions to Fassinger's original (1997) model are in italics.

Our revision of Fassinger's (1997) model includes an explicit evaluation of power and privilege, that is, the benefit of unearned assets (McIntosh, 1998), within the environment and within the relationship. Such an assessment will most likely involve a discussion of elements of diversity present within the relationship and the environment, including but not limited to race, gender, class, sexual orientation, and age. Differences are valued and explored rather than minimized, denied, or contained. The respect the mentor has for these differences facilitates the development of the mentee because it allows the mentee to struggle with professional goals while remaining grounded in her/his value system and culture, not the culture of the mentor. We agree with Fassinger (1997) that both the mentor and the mentee benefit from this evaluation of

differences. Such relationships result in mutuality, where both individuals can be authentically involved with one another. The mentor gains a true colleague while the mentee learns to trust and respect him/herself. Because of the mentor's respect for the mentee, the mentee feels competent and more able to fully participate in the training experience. We further argue that re-thinking vs. evaluating benefits society as well, because mentees who more fully participate in the training process also may attain a higher skill level.

One misconception associated with this dimension of mentoring is that one of the goals of a truly feminist, multicultural relationship should be to strive to create an environment where the mentor and the mentee have equal power. As Fassinger (1997) ably articulates such a goal is unattainable and counterproductive. Not only are there irrefutable power differences between a mentor and mentee, but such a goal makes it impossible to attend and explore power dynamics because an atmosphere of denial and oppression prevails.

EMPHASIS ON RELATIONAL

As described by Fassinger (1997), this dimension of the MFM model requires the mentor to be open and honest with her/his mentee. In essence, this dimension emphasizes the importance of being congruent and allowing the mentee to see the mentor as competent as well as uncertain and confused at times. The mentor values discussion about the mentoring relationship with the mentee and feedback is encouraged and exchanged. Attention is given both to the psychosocial as well as the instrumental aspects of the mentoring relationship.

In recognition that no one mentor can possibly meet all of the mentee's needs, mentees are encouraged to identify and express their needs, particularly as needs will likely change over the course of time. Mentors are advised to facilitate mentees' relationships with other role models, advisers, and mentors. We believe that since many mentors represent the majority group in our society, it is especially important that mentees from underrepresented groups are encouraged to identify and seek a "constellation" of mentors. Doing so allows mentees greater access to additional mentoring/sponsorship relationships that will better meet the mentee's needs.

In our revision of Fassinger's (1997) model, we articulate our preference that open discussions of multicultural issues take place so that the needs of the mentee can be identified. The responsibility for raising multicultural issues and concerns rests with the mentor, though decisions about how to best address these issues can be made mutually. Discussing multicultural issues with all mentees is important, even with those who may appear to be quite similar to the mentor, in order to address within-group differences. Further, some mentees will be part of a hidden minority (e.g., persons with a disability; gay, lesbian, bisexual, or transgendered persons; religious minorities) and might choose not to discuss their concerns without encouragement.

In addition to bearing responsibility for raising issues relevant to diversity, we believe it is important for mentors to be mindful of their assumptions about

members of diverse groups. Some mentors might automatically assume that it is imperative to discuss racial power dynamics with mentees who are of a different race. Results from the Thomas (1993) study of cross-racial developmental (e.g., mentoring) relationships indicate, however, that mentees at different stages of identity development have differing needs regarding discussing racial issues. Thus, not only do we recommend that mentors take responsibility for raising issues relative to race (as well as other elements of diversity), but we believe that ascertaining when such discussions are inappropriate or nonproductive also is essential. If mentors continually recognize and examine their assumptions in relationship to their mentees, mentees' development will likely be facilitated.

According to Fassinger (1997), both mentors and mentees benefit by attending to the relational aspect of the mentoring relationship. Mentees benefit by receiving support, developing networks, and gaining an appreciation of both the instrumental and the psychosocial aspects of relationships. The mentor benefits by gaining support, a greater understanding of multicultural issues, and possibly a future colleague.

One concern that emanates from this dimension of the MFM model is that a mentor will feel undervalued by the mentee should the mentee seek out other mentors and sponsors. In fact, a multicultural feminist mentor is aware of her/his strengths and limitations associated with her/his ability to nurture. Awareness of limitations is not viewed as a weakness but rather as a benefit to the mentee in two ways. First, it models humanness for mentees and helps to decrease the mentee's expectations that one is a failure if one cannot be all things to all people. Second, it gives the mentee the opportunity to pursue other avenues of growth and development.

VALUING OF COLLABORATION

This aspect of MFM reflects a work style that is both collaborative and communal. The contributions of mentees are considered critical to the outcome of joint projects. A mentor models her/his value for collaboration by establishing networks with a wide variety of professional colleagues and the mentee is brought into those existing networks as appropriate (Fassinger, 1997). Through an emphasis on collaboration, mentees gain hands-on experience and early involvement in professional activities. Our revision of Fassinger's (1997) model emphasizes that because diversity is valued, participation is not proscribed. Rather, mentees are encouraged to bring their unique perspective and contributions. Honoring and respecting the contributions of mentees is meaningful and relevant to those who have been marginalized both in society and in education and psychology.

As articulated by Fassinger (1997), mentees further benefit by having the opportunity to closely observe a model that values collaboration as well as respect for diverse perspectives. The mentor gains valuable task assistance often resulting in increased productivity. Because diverse perspectives are encouraged, outcomes

(e.g., a research study, counseling supervision) are often of higher quality, benefiting both the mentor and society as a whole.

Some multicultural feminist mentors may feel pressure to be bias-free and extraordinarily self-aware. In reality, becoming multiculturally competent is a process. Mentors who model the struggle to be self-aware and competent serve as a valuable role model for their mentees and further reinforce the notion that all mentors are in the process of developing themselves.

INTEGRATION OF DICHOTOMIES

Fassinger (1997) described this dimension as the development of a congruent sense of self and knowledge. The emphasis here is on "connected knowing" or the understanding that "knowledge is constructed within the contextual experiences and boundaries of the knower" (p. 14). Abstract knowledge, as well as attention to one's own experiences (both thinking and feeling), is valued. This awareness and integrative process results in greater self-congruency between both the mentor and the mentee.

With regard to diversity issues, our revision of Fassinger's model incorporates the perspective that many minority group members have been encouraged to disavow self-knowledge and to adopt a majority perspective. This dimension of MFM encourages the application and integration of self-knowledge (which takes place in a cultural context) to the more abstract information with which they are confronted. The holistic nature of this dimension suggests that the varied ways individuals think, feel, and perceive our world are all valuable.

Both the mentee and the mentor benefit by gaining or reinforcing a congruent sense of self. Mentees also benefit by learning to value "both abstract knowledge and personal feelings/experiences in self and others" (Fassinger, 1997, p. 14).

A multicultural feminist mentor may feel responsible for motivating mentees to develop the capacity to integrate their self-knowledge with educational content, the training environment context, and the political environment they are exposed to during their training experience. While multicultural feminist mentors value such reconciliation, mentors respect differences in the extent to which their mentees are willing to explore these issues, examine contradictions that emerge as a result of this process, and work toward their integration.

INCORPORATION OF POLITICAL ANALYSIS

Fassinger (1997) stated that this dimension relates to one of the cornerstones of feminist theory—that the personal is political—and reflects a belief that education and science are not value-free. Aspects of the institution that reflect mainstream values (e.g., sexism, racism, heterosexism, classism) are highlighted and confronted. Mentors challenge the status quo and accept the conflict that ensues.

We certainly see such a perspective as consistent with a multicultural approach. Multicultural feminist mentors value social justice and social advocacy. Such activities are respected, encouraged, and valued. Both the mentor and the mentee can choose to work together (or separately) to facilitate systemic change. Merely acknowledging the presence of stigmas is supportive of social action, and thus the mentee can gain power over the situations with which s/he is confronted. Thus, the mentee need not function in a null environment in which her/his beliefs, values, behaviors, and/or ideas are ignored or minimized.

We agree with Fassinger's (1997) articulation of the benefits to the mentor and the mentee in a feminist mentoring relationship. The mentee benefits by having a mentor who models commitment and integrity. Those mentees with a history of marginalization develop trust. Mentors are similarly re-empowered, as they have had a significant impact on the mentee. We further believe that the act of multicultural feminist mentoring in and of itself is a form of social action and advocacy. Multicultural feminist mentoring represents a departure from the status quo and serves to challenge and influence the context within which it exists (e.g., society, the field).

Some mentors may believe it is their responsibility to instill in mentees a desire to work on politically charged topics. In fact, MFM mentors, due to their deep respect for the mentee and their understanding that the mentoring relationship is first and foremost about the needs of the mentee, communicate their belief that mentees are able to reach well-considered decisions about their own professional activities. To require mentees to engage in social advocacy or social justice would be contrary to the spirit of the MFM model.

conclusion

Like Fassinger's (1997) model of feminist mentoring, our multicultural feminist model includes the following dimensions: re-thinking of power, emphasis on relational, valuing of collaboration, integration of dichotomies, and incorporation of political analysis. Our revision primarily consisted of infusing attention to multicultural issues in each of the aforementioned dimensions. Thus, we have eliminated "commitment to diversity" as a separate dimension from Fassinger's (1997) model and incorporated attention to diversity explicitly throughout the model. We believe the integration of multicultural issues prioritizes and centralizes these concerns.

The MFM model is not without its challenges. Mentors and mentees often lack a shared definition of mentoring. Failure to articulate the MFM model may result in misunderstanding and conflict. Further, appropriate boundaries with mentees need to be established to avoid abuses of power while simultaneously establishing and maintaining a warm and supportive relationship. Mentees and mentors may have limited experience with the type of mentoring

relationship proposed, necessitating consultation with experienced mentors and frank discussions between mentors and mentees. In addition, our conceptualization of MFM is based on western worldviews. For example, efforts to empower mentees with different worldviews might be perceived as quite disempowering, and quite contrary to the mentor's intention. Remembering to remain respectful and mindful of the mentees' best interests is essential for navigating through such complicated situations. Finally, though our model has been informed by both empirical research and scholarly thought, it is untested and in need of empirical study.

Colley (2000) raises the question: Is it possible to equalize/democratize the mentoring relationship? We believe the answer is yes. Adherence to a MFM model decreases the likelihood that mentors and mentees will be misled about the rewards and challenges that naturally present themselves during the mentoring process, similar to the complex but productive relationships that often occur in real life. The combination of sensitivity to multicultural issues as well as the relational aspect of mentoring works synergistically to produce mentoring experiences that better meet the needs of diverse professionals.

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